As millions stayed awake through the night in early July to watch Cabo Verde's spirited performance against defending champions Argentina at the 2026 FIFA World Cup, football fans in India wondered how a tiny archipelago off the coast of Africa, only slightly bigger than Goa, is squaring up against footballing giants, while even qualifying for the tournament remains a distant dream for India. The sorry state of Indian football showed when India was forced to withdraw from the 2026 Asian Games because the men's team failed to satisfy the Union sports ministry's criterion of being among Asia's top eight. India ranks 24 among the 46 members of the Asian Football Confederation (AFC) and the team failed to qualify yet again for the AFC Asian Cup 2027, the foremost competition in the continent. India's quest to make history collapsed in 2024 itself in the second round of the AFC qualifiers. Competing in Group A alongside Qatar, Kuwait and Afghanistan, it failed to secure a top two finish needed to progress in the World Cup qualifiers. The Blue Tigers managed just one win—against Kuwait—their first away win in 22 years.



The picture is even more dismal when it comes to world football rankings. India has been on a downward spiral—from 102 in 2023 to 139 in 2026. Its highest FIFA ranking remains 94, achieved in 1996 under Bhaichung Bhutia's captaincy, while its second-best ranking of 96 came in 2017—the year India hosted the FIFA Under-17 World Cup, the biggest-ever FIFA event it hosted. It was hailed as the beginning of a footballing renaissance, as stadiums were modernised, crowds turned up in unprecedented numbers and the All India Football Federation (AIFF) spoke of creating a lasting legacy. At least 18 players from 10 countries that participated in it are playing in the 2026 World Cup. India, which hoped to ride the momentum into a new era, appears to have drifted further away, even as tiny Curacao, a Caribbean island with a population of 158,000, and the small nation of Cabo Verde, with half a million people, have taken advantage of the expanded, 48-team version of the 2026 World Cup and qualified. Not only did they improve infrastructure at home, they also drew heavily on their football-playing diasporas from across the leagues in Europe.

IMPERFECT STRUCTURE

Indian football is governed by the AIFF, the apex body affiliated to FIFA and the AFC. The AIFF oversees the national teams, youth development and domestic competitions, but unlike the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI), it does not exercise complete authority over the sport. Football clubs are independent entities that own player contracts and decide when to release players for national duty. National football coaches frequently struggle to assemble a settled squad and secure adequate preparation time before international tournaments.

The domestic football pyramid is headed by the Indian Super League (ISL), followed by the I-League, I-League 2 and I-League 3, with state leagues forming the base. A few top ISL stars can earn between Rs 2 crore and Rs 8 crore a season, but most Indian footballers make between Rs 8 lakh and Rs 60 lakh annually, while players in the I-League often earn Rs 3 lakh to Rs 15 lakh a year. In contrast, even an uncapped player in the Indian Premier League can command a base auction price of Rs 30 lakh, with many established

WHERE INDIA STANDS
(WORLD FOOTBALL RANKING)*

139	94
2026	1996

*As determined by FIFA